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the possibilities of making larger displays with wider market appeal (read affordable prices). After all people use computers for a multitude of reasons and not all uses necessitate a larger display.

At the very outset both LCD and plasma display technologies are very different from one another and were aimed at totally different markets. While the technical aspects of their working are beyond the purview of this test plasma displays were never really aimed at home users. Rather they were aimed at corporate users who would use such displays for presentations, displays in malls and other areas where a mass viewing audience is expected. For this reason plasma displays have always been manufactured in larger screen sizes. In fact it's only recently that plasma displays became available in screen sizes of 42-inches; mainly to serve the needs of the lower rungs of the market. Prior to this, plasma displays have always had huge screen sizes; to the tune of 65-inches and upwards. It's not uncommon to see plasma displays cross the 100-inch mark, obviously their price scales accordingly. LCD, on the other hand is a technology that was pushed towards the consumer markets first. While plasmas started at the higher screen sizes and moved downwards, LCDs did the reverse and started from the smaller screen sizes. The most common LCD displays are the 26-inch and 32-inch categories. Due to this peculiarity, the larger screen LCDs are disproportionately expensive when compared to the smaller size displays. For example, a 32-inch LCD TV may cost Rs 45,000 while a 42-inch display may cost as much as Rs 80,000 meaning that you pay some 43 percent more for just 10-inches more of display size. Obviously a plasma display with a larger screen would be costlier than a smaller one, but this difference is not as much as in the case of LCDs. Therefore, when buying a plasma TV, remember that the larger the screen, the higher the price, but you pay proportionately less for more on-screen real estate.

The debate over which technology is better is an eternal one and personally we have no favourites. If you want something in the region of 50-inches or larger we recommend looking at a plasma display as they offer more value for money, while for anything under 50-inches but bigger than

37-inches, it's a tie. If you want something in the region of 37-inches or less — it's LCD all the way. Of course people have their favourites and there are those who claim that the phosphor gas inside a plasma display loses its working efficiency after around 20,000 hours and therefore plasma displays have shorter life spans. This is not really true and the life span of the latest plasma displays is around 30,000 hours which is the same as some LCD displays and at worst around 15,000 hours worse than most LCDs. Plasmas also have an issue with burn-in whereby due to uneven wear on the phosphors if a static image is left to be displayed on the screen for a long time, this image ends up leaving a ghost image on the display behind. This is called burn-in; as the image appears to be burned into the screen. While we have verified that this is indeed an issue if left unchecked; most plasmas these days come with inbuilt screen savers that do not allow a static image to remain on-screen for very long. However, burn-in is a minus point for plasma displays. Contrary to belief LCD displays can never suffer from burn-in because they work on the principle of blocking light unlike a plasma display that actually produces light. This is why an LCD is referred to as a *transmissive* display. A plasma display in contrast works on the principle of emission and plasmas are *emissive* displays. Quite simply LCDs do not produce light themselves but simply allow through or block light that is produced by a CCFL tube or (the more recent) LED source. In the simple benefit of a plasma display over an LCD is the fact that you can buy a much larger screen for a cheaper price. Some also claim that plasma displays offers deeper blacks than most LCDs and also offer wider viewing angles. While we agree on the latter somewhat, the former is definitely up for debate.



Sony KDL-70X3500: Goliath

The KDL-70X3500 is a long name for a huge 70-inch display. We were expecting



Sony KDL-70X3500

a plasma display when we heard we were getting a 70-inch unit from Sony, but it turned out to be an LCD. To say its bulky would be an understatement, obviously due to its massive size. The wide bezel doesn't help things and makes the unit appear even larger, especially since the rather wide speaker grilles are built into the sides. Additionally the outer portion of the bezel has a transparent fibre strip running along the entire outer dimension of the display. Sony really wanted this display to appear as large as it possibly could; this is not exactly a plus if space is a premium. The stand is quite small considering the bulk of the display; surprisingly it is very stable and the display does not tilt even a bit. The KDL-70X3500 is rich with connectivity options although it misses out on DVI or Display Port connects. The connectors are located on the rear and to the left; which means they are accessible even if the display is slap bang against a wall.

Once we calibrated this display we noticed that the Spyder 3 Elite had really toned down on the red component. Pre calibration this display was plagued with a very highly saturated red and any part of any scene with this colour appeared too rich to the eye. Post calibration the red component was more neutral but it still tended to be high. Display Mate showed that this display has a decent contrast ratio. Watching movies was a good experience mainly because despite its size, there was hardly any pixellation noticeable which was surprising for such a large display; since the pixel pitch is normally higher on larger displays. Although the display supports 1080p natively, even 720p and DVD-resolution movies looked good.

Sony advertises this one as the largest LCD display available and frankly 70-inch LCDs are an elite bunch. Exclusivity doesn't come cheap though and this one is priced at (brace yourself) Rs 20,00,000; in case you messed up on the count of zeroes its price is *twenty lakhs*, which is a sizable chunk of dough. Unless you own a yacht and your very own private island we don't reckon you indulge this sinful, sinful extravagance. In any case if its size that matters, you could probably buy a 100+ inch plasma display for less. It did win our Best Performance award, but the trophy was shared since two displays came very close to each other.

Philips 52PFL9703/98: Large and lovely

Barely had our sore backs recovered from lugging the massive 70-inch Sony around and we had to handle this beast. The 52PFL9703/98 is a 52-inch LCD display from Philips and once we unpackaged it we spent a couple of minutes looking it over, running covetous hands all over it. It's